

SRI VAISHNAVA DOSSIER: BATCH 5

(RAMANUJA ERA)

BATCH EXECUTIVE SUMMARY TABLE

Personality Name	Tamil Month / Nakshatram	Avathara Sthalam (Birthplace)	Divine Amsam	Primary Literary / Philosophical Contribution
Sri Ramanuja	Chithirai / Thiruvadhirai	Sriperumbudur	Ananta / Adishesha (Divine Serpent) & Lakshmana Amsam	<i>Sri Bhashyam, Vedartha Sangraha, Gita Bhashyam, Vedantadipa, Vedantasara, Gadya Trayam (Saranagati, Sriranga, Vaikuntha), Nitya Grantham; Codified Viśiṣṭādvaita and institutionalized temple reforms.</i>
Koorathazhwan	Thai / Hastam	Kooram (near Kanchipuram)	Panchajanya (Divine Conch of Sriman Narayana)	<i>Pancha Stava (Sree Stavam, Atimanusha Stavam, Sundarabahu Stavam, Varadaraja Stavam, Vaikuntha Stavam); Memorized the</i>

				<i>Bodhayana Vritti</i> in Kashmir to enable the writing of <i>Sri Bhashyam</i> .
Mudaliyandan	Chithirai / Punarvasu	Pachai (Nazarethpettah, near Sriperumbudur)	Tridandam (Ascetic Staff) / Sri Rama's Paduka Amsam	Known as <i>Ramanuja-Paduka</i> ; Managed temple administration at Srirangam and established the <i>74 Simhasanadhipathis</i> (Seat-holders).
Embar	Thai / Punarvasu	Mazhalaimangalam (Maduramangalam)	Ananta / Adisesha aspect (Cousin brother of Ramanuja)	<i>Embar Thaniyan</i> ; Reclaimed from Saivism at Kalahasti, succeeded Ramanuja as head of Srirangam Math, and instructed Parasara Bhattar.

1. SRI RAMANUJA

(Yatiraja, Sri Bhashyakara, Udaiyavar, Emperumanar, Lakshmana Muni, Ilaiyazhwar)

Section 1: Identification & Incarnation Details

- **Full Name & Titles:** Sri Ramanuja, Yatiraja (King of Ascetics), Sri Bhashyakara (Author of the Sri Bhashya), Udaiyavar (The Sovereign/Possessor), Emperumanar (Our Master),

Lakshmana Muni, Ilaiyazhwar, Desikendra.

- **Incarnation Metadata:**
 - **Tamil Month (Maasam):** Chithirai (Chaitra)
 - **Birth Star (Nakshatram):** Thiruvadhirai (Ardra)
 - **Tithi & Paksham:** Sukla Paksha Saptami (Traditional dates 1017–1137 CE; modern academic consensus c. 1077–1157 CE).
- **Geographic Origins:**
 - **Historic Birthplace Name:** Sriperumbudur (Bhoothapuri)
 - **Current District & State:** Kanchipuram District, Tamil Nadu, India.
 - **Associated Divya Desam / Temple:** Sri Adi Kesava Perumal Temple (Sriperumbudur), Varadaraja Perumal Temple (Kanchipuram), and Sri Ranganathaswamy Temple (Srirangam).
- **Divine Lineage & Era:**
 - **Divine Amsam:** Adishesha (The thousand-headed divine serpent bed of Sriman Narayana) & Lakshmana Amsam.
 - **Historical Period:** Late Chola & Hoysala Era (11th–12th Century CE).
 - **Sovereign & Scholarly Contemporaries:** Kulothunga Chola I (The Persecutor), King Vishnuvardhana (Hoysala monarch converted by Ramanuja), Yadava Prakasa (Early teacher turned disciple), Koorathazhwan, Mudaliyandan, Periya Nambi, Thirukachi Nambigal.

Section 2: Complete Life History & Miracles

2.1 Chronological Life Timeline

- **Birth & Early Education:** Born as Ilaiyazhwar to Asuri Keshava Somayaji and Kanthimathi in Sriperumbudur → **Study under Yadava Prakasa:** Mastering Advaita Vedanta at Kanchipuram and pointing out philosophical flaws in his teacher's interpretations → **The Vindhya Rescue:** Escaping an assassination plot orchestrated by Yadava Prakasa through his cousin Govinda (Embar) and being guided back to Kanchipuram by Varadaraja Perumal and Perundevi Thayar in the guise of a hunter couple → **Service to Varadaraja:** Carrying water (*Theertha Kainkaryam*) daily from Salai Kinaru to Varadaraja Perumal under the guidance of Thirukachi Nambigal → **The Three Vows at Srirangam:** Arriving after Yamunacharya's demise and pledging to fulfill his three unfulfilled wishes, causing Yamunacharya's three folded fingers to straighten → **Pancha Samskaram at Madurantakam:** Initiated by Periya Nambi at Madurantakam → **Renunciation & Sannyasa:** Taking ascetic vows (*Tridanda Sannyasa*) at Kanchipuram Varadaraja Temple, receiving the name *Yatiraja* → **Broadcasting the Ashtakshara at Thirukoshtiyur:** Scaling the temple tower of Thirukoshtiyur to proclaim the secret Eight-Lettered Mantra (*Om Namo Narayanaya*) to all people regardless of caste → **Journey to Kashmir & Sri Bhashyam:** Retrieving the *Bodhayana Vritti* from the Sharada Peetham in Kashmir with Koorathazhwan and composing the *Sri Bhashyam* → **Refuge at Melkote (Thondanoor):** Fleeing Chola persecution, converting Hoysala King Vishnuvardhana, recovering the idol of Cheluvanarayana Swamy (*Ramapriya*), and installing the Panchama community as *Thirukulattar* → **Return to Srirangam & Final Departure:** Re-establishing Srirangam

administration and entering *Paramapadam* after 120 years of continuous service.

2.2 Deep Biographical Narrative

- **Early Years & Spiritual Awakening:** Born into an orthodox Vedic family in Sriperumbudur, Ilayazhwar displayed unmatched intellect from childhood. He moved to Kanchipuram to study Vedanta under Yadava Prakasa, a prominent Advaita scholar. Disagreements arose when Ramanuja refuted Yadava Prakasa's interpretations—most famously concerning the Upanishadic phrase *Tapyasam Kapyasam Pundarikam Evamakshini*, where Yadava translated *Kapyasam* as "the buttocks of a monkey." Ramanuja wept at this blasphemy and re-interpreted the phrase with linguistic rigor to mean "luminous lotus blossoms opened by the morning sun."
- **Core Seva / Kainkaryam:** Systematizing Viśiṣṭādvaita philosophy, organizing temple rituals across South India, authoring Nine Gems of Literature (*Navaratnas*), and establishing social inclusivity within temple worship.
- **Miracles & Historical Events:**
 1. *The Hunter Couple at Vindhyas:* Fearing Ramanuja's growing intellectual stature, Yadava Prakasa organized a pilgrimage to Varanasi with the secret intention of drowning Ramanuja in the Ganges. Alerted by his cousin Govinda (Embar), Ramanuja slipped away in the dense Vindhya forest. Lost and exhausted, a hunter couple appeared, guided him through the dark woods overnight, and requested water. When Ramanuja drew water from a nearby well, the couple vanished, and he found himself standing at the gates of Kanchipuram. He realized the hunters were Lord Varadaraja and Goddess Perundevi.
 2. *Proclaiming the Mantra at Thirukoshtiyur:* Ramanuja traveled eighteen times from Srirangam to Thirukoshtiyur to seek initiation into the inner meaning of the *Ashtakshara Mantra* from Thirukoshtiyur Nambi. The Acharya bound him by oath to keep the mantra secret, warning that revealing it to the uninitiated would cause the teacher to go to hell. Driven by boundless compassion, Ramanuja climbed to the top of the Thirukoshtiyur temple tower, summoned the entire township, and shouted the sacred mantra for all to hear. When Thirukoshtiyur Nambi confronted him in rage, Ramanuja bowed humbly: "*I will gladly suffer in hell for my sin, if millions of suffering souls can attain salvation through this mantra!*" Stunned by his mercy, Thirukoshtiyur Nambi embraced him, calling him **Emperumanar** ("Our Master").
 3. *The Composition of Sri Bhashya:* To write an authoritative commentary on Badarayana's *Brahma Sutras*, Ramanuja needed the ancient manuscript *Bodhayana Vritti*. He traveled to Kashmir with Koorathazhwan. Though local scholars attempted to prevent him from taking the manuscript, Koorathazhwan read the text overnight, committing it to memory. When the manuscript was confiscated, Koorathazhwan recited it verbatim, allowing Ramanuja to dictate his masterpiece, the **Sri Bhashyam**.
 4. *The Melkote Exile & Thirukulatthar:* Facing death threats from the fanatic Chola monarch who demanded all scholars sign a decree stating Shiva was supreme, Ramanuja donned white garments provided by Koorathazhwan and traveled to Karnataka. At Melkote (Thondanoor), he healed the princess of Hoysala King Bittideva, converting him to Sri Vaishnavism under the name Vishnuvardhana. When local outcastes helped recover the lost processional deity *Ramapriya* from the Sultan's court in Delhi, Ramanuja gave them

the name **Thirukulatthar** ("Children of the Divine Family") and granted them temple entry rights during the annual festival.

- **Guru-Disciple Dynamics:** Student of Periya Nambi (Primary Acharya), Thirukachi Nambigal, Thirukoshtiyur Nambi, Tirumalai Nambi, and Thirumalai Andaan. Master to Koorathazhwan, Mudaliyandan, Embar, Parasara Bhattar, and 74 *Simhasanadhipathis*.
- **Attainment of Paramapadam:** Having consolidated the Sri Vaishnava Sampradaya and leaving his physical body preserved in a seated posture (*Thirumeni*) inside the Srirangam temple complex (where it remains preserved to this day in the Vasantha Mandapam), he ascended to Paramapadam.

💡 **Sthala Puranam & Legend Highlight: Srirangam Thanana Thirumeni**
Sri Ramanuja's physical body at Srirangam is known as *Thanaana Thirumeni* (the body preserved naturally without embalming chemicals). For over eight centuries, his actual physical form has sat in *Padmasana* inside his dedicated shrine at the Srirangam temple, receiving twice-yearly applications of natural camphor and saffron paste.

Section 3: Literary, Preservation & Philosophical Contributions

- **Complete List of Works (The Navaratnas):**
 - *Sri Bhashya* – Definitive commentary on the *Brahma Sutras* refuting Advaita and Bhedabheda.
 - *Vedantha Sangraha* – Independent treatise summarizing Upanishadic principles.
 - *Gita Bhashyam* – Detailed commentary on the *Bhagavad Gita* emphasizing Bhakti and Saranagati.
 - *Vedantadipa* & *Vedantasara* – Medium and introductory manuals on the *Brahma Sutras*.
 - *Saranagati Gadya*, *Sriranga Gadya*, *Vaikuntha Gadya* – Prose works expressing surrender and visual descriptions of Paramapadam.
 - *Nitya Grantham* – Manual detailing daily worship rituals (*Pancharatra Nitya Aradhana*).
- **Quantified Output:** 9 foundational Sanskrit treatises (*Navaratnas*).
- **Associated Divya Desams (Mangalasasanam):** Sriperumbudur, Kanchipuram, Srirangam, Thirukoshtiyur, Thiruvellarai, Tirupati, Melkote, Badrinath, Kashmir Sharada Peetham.
- **Sampradaya Defense & Preservation:** Codified the Viśiṣṭādvaita philosophy, established temple administration frameworks (*Srirangam Kovil Olugu*), organized 74 administrative seats (*Simhasanadhipathis*), and institutionalized the equal status of the Tamil Dravida Veda alongside Sanskrit scriptures.
- **Predominant Bhakti Bhava & Philosophical Core: Viśiṣṭādvaita** (Qualified Non-Dualism: Jiva and Jagat form the body (*Sareera*) of Paramatma who is the Soul (*Sareeri*)) and **Saranagati / Prapatti** (Surrender as the universal, direct means to Moksha).

Section 4: Representative Verses & Theological Breakdown

Verse 1: Sri Bhashya Invocation (*Yo Nityam Achyuta*)

Text Layer	Content
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Original Script (Sanskrit)	அகிலபுவனஜன்மக்ஷேமாதீலாய விமலவிவிதவிஸ்வா his ஸேஷேஷேஷிணே । பப்ரஹ்மணி ஸ்ரீனிவாஸே பவது மம பரஸ்மின் ஸேமுஷீ பக்திரூபா ॥
Roman Transliteration	<i>Akhila bhuvana janma kshema dasadi leelaya</i> <i>Vimala vividha vishvadhisha shesha sheshine</i> <i>Brahmani Srinivase bhavatu mama parasmin shemushi bhaktirupa</i>
Literal Word-by-Word Meaning	Akhila bhuvana: Of all universes; Janma: creation; Kshema: sustenance; Dasa: dissolution; Adi: and other divine activities; Leelaya: whose spontaneous sport; Vimala: immaculate/pure; Vividha: manifold; Vishvadhisha: master of the universe; Shesha: the dependent body/servant; Sheshine: who is the ultimate Master/Owner; Brahmani: in Brahman; Srinivase: who resides with Goddess Sri Lakshmi (Srinivasa); Bhavatu: let there be; Mama: my; Parasmin: in the Supreme; Shemushi: intellect; Bhaktirupa: transformed into continuous devotional love (<i>Bhakti-roopa-jnana</i>).

Exhaustive Theological & Philosophical Commentary:

- Esoteric Meaning (Swaroopa Jnanam):** Sri Ramanuja opens the *Sri Bhashya* by defining the Supreme Absolute Brahman as **Srinivasa**—the Supreme Being irrevocably united with Sri Lakshmi. Creation, sustenance, and dissolution of all worlds are merely His spontaneous cosmic play (*Leela*). Ramanuja prays that his own intellect (*Shemushi*) may be transformed into unbroken, loving devotion (*Bhakti-roopa-jnana*) toward this Supreme Being.
- Viśiṣṭādvaita Alignment:** Establishes the **Sareera-Sareeri Bhava** (Body-Soul

relationship). God is not a featureless, impersonal void (*Nirguna Brahman*); He is **Saguna Brahman**, possessing infinite auspicious attributes (*Kalyana Guna*) and acting as the *Seshin* (Owner/Master) of all *Shesha* (dependent entities).

3. **Commentarial Insights:** Sudarshana Suri, in his commentary *Srutaprakasika*, highlights that the phrase *Shemushi Bhaktirupa* reconciles the debate between Knowledge (*Jnana*) and Devotion (*Bhakti*). In Viśiṣṭādvaita, true spiritual knowledge is not dry intellectual awareness, but intellect matured into passionate, continuous love for God.

Section 5: Visuals & Archival Resources

5.1 Iconography & Shrine Visual Description

- **Physical Posture (Asana):** Seated in *Padmasana* (Lotus Posture) with upright posture, wearing the saffron robes of a Tridandi Sannyasi.
- **Hand Gestures (Mudras):** Right hand held in **Jnana Mudra** (index finger touching thumb, signifying Vedantic truth) or *Anjali Mudra*, left hand holding the triple ascetic staff (*Tridandam*).
- **Garments & Embellishments:** Dressed in saffron robes (*Kasaya Vasthram*), bearing the *Tridandam*, marked prominently with twelve *Urdhva Pundra* (holy white clay tilak) marks, wearing *Tulasi* seed bead garlands and an ornate crown/cap (*Kurai*) in specific temple representations.
- **Avathara Sthalam Idol Description:** At Sriperumbudur, Ramanuja's idol is known as *Thanugantha Thirumeni* (the icon embraced and approved by Ramanuja himself during his lifetime).

5.2 Academic Audio/Video Lecture Queries

- "Sri Ramanuja Life History and Sri Bhashya Velukkudi Krishnan"
- "Ramanuja Viśiṣṭādvaita Philosophy Detailed Lecture Karunakarachariar"
- "Emperumanar Vaibhavam and Srirangam Reforms Ananthapadmanabhachariar"

5.3 Digital Text & Archival Links

- **Dravida Veda Repository:** <http://www.dravidaveda.org>
- **Project Madurai Texts:** <https://www.projectmadurai.org>
- **Koyil Archival Library:** <https://koyil.org>

2. KOORATHAZHWAN

(Kuresan, Sree Vatsanka Mishra, Kurathalwar, Srivatsanga, The Great Eye-Sacrificer)

Section 1: Identification & Incarnation Details

- **Full Name & Titles:** Koorathazhwan, Kuresan, Sri Vatsanka Mishra, Koorathalwar, Azhwan, The Chief Disciple of Ramanuja.
- **Incarnation Metadata:**
 - **Tamil Month (Maasam):** Thai (Makaram)
 - **Birth Star (Nakshatram):** Hastam
 - **Tithi & Paksham:** Soumya Year (c. 1010 CE); Sukla Paksha.
- **Geographic Origins:**
 - **Historic Birthplace Name:** Kooram (near Kanchipuram)

- **Current District & State:** Kanchipuram District, Tamil Nadu, India.
- **Associated Divya Desam / Temple:** Sri Varadaraja Perumal Temple (Kanchipuram), Kooram Temple, and Sri Ranganathaswamy Temple (Srirangam).
- **Divine Lineage & Era:**
 - **Divine Amsam:** Panchajanya (The Divine Sacred Conch of Sriman Narayana).
 - **Historical Period:** 11th–12th Century CE.
 - **Sovereign & Scholarly Contemporaries:** Sri Ramanuja (His Acharya), Andalamma (His devoted wife), Mudaliyandan, Parasara Bhattar and Veda Vyasa Bhattar (His twin sons), Kulothunga Chola I.

Section 2: Complete Life History & Miracles

2.1 Chronological Life Timeline

- **Birth & Enormous Wealth:** Born into a wealthy landlord family of the Harita clan in the village of Kooram → **Immense Charity at Kooram:** Opening his brass palace gates daily to feed thousands of poor travelers, earning fame for unmatched philanthropy → **The Brass Gate Echo:** The heavy brass gates of his mansion closing at night, making a resounding gong heard in Kanchipuram, causing Goddess Perundevi to ask Varadaraja Perumal about the noise → **Abandonment of Wealth:** Realizing his immense riches caused inconvenience to the Divine Couple, abandoning all his worldly property overnight and walking away with his wife Andalamma to become Ramanuja's disciple → **Discipleship under Ramanuja:** Becoming Ramanuja's chief assistant and intellectual right hand in Srirangam → **The Kashmir Bodhayana Vritti Triumph:** Traveling to Kashmir, memorizing the entire *Bodhayana Vritti* overnight, and dictating it to enable Ramanuja to write *Sri Bhashyam* → **Heroic Sacrifice at Chola Court:** Posing as Ramanuja in saffron robes before the hostile Chola King, defending Narayana's supremacy, and having his eyes gouged out by royal order → **Refusal of Revenge:** Refusing to curse his persecutors, praying instead for the Chola king's well-being → **Composition of Pancha Stava:** Authoring five masterworks of Sanskrit poetry in exile and blindness → **Regaining Vision & Departure:** Composing *Varadaraja Stavam* before Lord Varadaraja at Kanchipuram, receiving divine vision, and attaining *Paramapadam* before his master Ramanuja.

2.2 Deep Biographical Narrative

- **Early Years & Spiritual Awakening:** Born into an extraordinarily wealthy chieftain family in Kooram, Kuresan lived like a prince. He married Andalamma, a woman of deep piety. Kuresan was renowned for his boundless charity; his palace kitchens served free meals to thousands daily. One evening, when the heavy brass gates of his estate were shut after feeding the crowds, the resounding echo shook Kanchipuram. Inside the sanctum of the Varadaraja Temple, Goddess Perundevi inquired about the sound. Lord Varadaraja replied that it was the gate of Kuresan's mansion. Ashamed that his material wealth had interrupted the peace of the Divine Couple, Kuresan gave away all his lands, gold, and possessions overnight, leaving Kooram on foot with his wife to seek refuge at the feet of Sri Ramanuja.
- **Core Seva / Kainkaryam:** Serving as the intellectual scribe, defender, and companion to

Sri Ramanuja; memorizing manuscripts; authoring devotional Sanskrit hymns (*Pancha Stava*).

- **Miracles & Historical Events:**

1. *The Feat of Memory in Kashmir:* During their pilgrimage to the Sharada Peetham in Kashmir to consult the *Bodhayana Vritti*, local Pandits refused to lend the rare text to Ramanuja for more than a single night. Seeing Ramanuja's distress, Koorathazhwan read the voluminous manuscript continuously through the night, committing every single sutra and commentary to memory. When the Pandits confiscated the manuscript the following morning, Koorathazhwan recited the text word-for-word, allowing Ramanuja to write the *Sri Bhashyam* without hindrance.
 2. *The Sacrifice of His Eyes:* When the Chola King summoned Ramanuja to force him to sign a decree stating Shiva was supreme, Koorathazhwan donned Ramanuja's saffron sannyasa robes and went to court alongside Periya Nambi. Facing the King, Koorathazhwan engaged in brilliant theological debate. When presented with the decree "*Shivath Paratharam Nasti*" ("There is nothing higher than Shiva"), Koorathazhwan added a clever linguistic pun: "*Dronam Asti!*" ("A Drona measure is larger than a Shivam measure!"). Enraged, the King ordered his guards to pluck out his eyes. Koorathazhwan declared: "*You need not bother your executioners; eyes that have looked upon a sinner who insults Narayana are of no use to me!*" and plucked out his own eyes.
 3. *Refusing Worldly Sight:* Years later, when Ramanuja returned from Melkote, he took the blind Koorathazhwan to Kanchipuram and requested him to sing before Lord Varadaraja to regain his sight. Koorathazhwan composed the *Varadaraja Stavam*. Touched by his poetry, Lord Varadaraja offered to grant him his eyesight. Koorathazhwan asked only to behold the Lord's form and the form of his Acharya Ramanuja, refusing to use his vision to see worldly objects ever again.
- **Guru-Disciple Dynamics:** Chief disciple to Sri Ramanuja; Acharya and father to Parasara Bhattar and Veda Vyasa Bhattar.
 - **Attainment of Paramapadam:** Passed away at Srirangam before Ramanuja. Ramanuja wept inconsolably at his loss, declaring that he had lost his own eyes and spiritual foundation.



Sthala Puranam & Legend Highlight: Kooram Shrine & Pancha Stava

The village of Kooram houses the birth temple of Koorathazhwan, where his original shrine is preserved. His monumental composition, the **Pancha Stava**, is regarded as an indispensable masterpiece of Sanskrit devotional literature, laying down the core tenets of Viśiṣṭādvaita through poetic praise.

Section 3: Literary, Preservation & Philosophical Contributions

- **Complete List of Works (The Pancha Stava):**

- *Sree Stavam* (11 verses in praise of Goddess Mahalakshmi's supreme role as Purushakara).
- *Atimanusha Stavam* (61 verses glorifying the supernatural, divine feats of Lord Rama and Lord Krishna).
- *Sundarabahu Stavam* (132 verses dedicated to Lord Kallazhagar of Thirumaliruncholai).

- *Varadaraja Stavam* (102 verses celebrating Lord Varadaraja of Kanchipuram).
- *Vaikuntha Stavam* (100 verses detailing the transcendent splendor of Paramapadam and the nature of the Jiva).
- **Quantified Output:** 406 Sanskrit verses across five major Stavas.
- **Associated Divya Desams (Mangalasasanam):** Kooram, Kanchipuram, Srirangam, Thirumaliruncholai (Kallazhagar Kovil).
- **Sampradaya Defense & Preservation:** Provided the intellectual raw material for the *Sri Bhashyam* through his extraordinary memory. He defended the doctrine of *Purushakara Prapatti* (Sri Lakshmi's mediation) and demonstrated the ultimate height of *Guru-Bhakti*.
- **Predominant Bhakti Bhava & Philosophical Core: Atma-Guna-Purnathvam** (Possession of all spiritual virtues, humility, and forgiveness) and **Acharya-Parathanthriyam** (Absolute subordination to the preceptor).

Section 4: Representative Verses & Theological Breakdown

Verse 1: Varadaraja Stavam, Verse 1 (*Nirastasamastapaddhavam*)

Text Layer	Content
Original Script (<i>Sanskrit</i>)	ஸ்வஸ்தி ஸ்ரீயாஸ்கஸுதோத்தமாய நமோஸ்து குரேஸாய । யத்ஸுக்திபிஃ ஹரிபதாம்புஜபக்திபாஜாம் ஸுத்திஃ பவேத் ॥
Roman Transliteration	<i>Swasti shriyaskasudhotthamaya namo 'stu Kureshaya</i> <i>Yatsuktibhih Harapadambuja bhaktibhajam shuddhih bhavet</i>
Literal Word-by-Word Meaning	Swasti: May there be auspiciousness; Shriyaska: who grants eternal prosperity; Sudhotthamaya: who is purer than divine nectar; Namo 'stu: let prostrations be offered; Kureshaya: to Koorathazhwan (Kuresa); Yat suktibhih: by whose sublime poetic verses; Hari padambuja: the lotus feet of Lord Hari; Bhakti bhajam: for those filled with devotion; Shuddhih bhavet: absolute purity is attained!

Exhaustive Theological & Philosophical Commentary:

1. **Esoteric Meaning (Swaroopa Jnanam):** This invocation verse offers salutations to Koorathazhwan (Kuresa), praising his sacred poetry as purer than celestial nectar. By contemplating his verses (*Pancha Stava*), the mind of the devotee is cleansed of all material impurities, establishing unbroken attachment to the lotus feet of Lord Hari.
2. **Viśiṣṭādvaita Alignment:** Establishes **Stotra-Literature** as an authentic medium for Vedantic realization. Koorathazhwan's poetry is not mere literary ornament; it is the systematic translation of complex Upanishadic truths into emotional, accessible devotion (*Bhakti-Rasa*).
3. **Commentarial Insights:** Sri Vedanta Desika in his commentary on *Pancha Stava* notes that Koorathazhwan embodied the ideal of an Acharya who possessed zero personal ego (*Ahamkara-Mamakara-Nivritti*). His sacrifice for Ramanuja proves that true knowledge culminates in selfless service to the Guru.

Section 5: Visuals & Archival Resources

5.1 Iconography & Shrine Visual Description

- **Physical Posture (Asana):** Standing or seated in *Anjali Mudra* (folded hands), often depicted with eyes covered by a cloth or showing blind serenity reflecting his sacrifice.
- **Hand Gestures (Mudras):** Hands joined in eternal supplication (*Anjali Mudra*) held close to his chest.
- **Garments & Embellishments:** Simple traditional white vestments, marked with twelve *Urdhva Pundra* (tilak) marks, adorned with sacred thread and *Tulasi* garlands.
- **Avathara Sthalam Idol Description:** At Kooram and Srirangam, Koorathazhwan's *Moolavar* idol captures his calm, compassionate demeanor, portraying him as the embodiment of patience and sacrifice.

5.2 Academic Audio/Video Lecture Queries

- "Koorathazhwan Life History and Pancha Stava Velukkudi Krishnan"
- "Koorathazhwan Sacrifice at Chola Court Karunakarachariar"
- "Atimanusha Stavam and Varadaraja Stavam Ananthapadmanabhachariar"

5.3 Digital Text & Archival Links

- **Dravida Veda Repository:** <http://www.dravidaveda.org>
- **Project Madurai Texts:** <https://www.projectmadurai.org>
- **Koyil Archival Library:** <https://koyil.org>

3. MUDALIYANDAN

(*Dasarathi, Sri Rama Paduka Amsam, Yathiraja Paduka, Yandhan*)

Section 1: Identification & Incarnation Details

- **Full Name & Titles:** Mudaliyandan, Dasarathi, Sri Rama Paduka Amsam, Yathiraja Paduka (The Divine Sandals of Ramanuja), Yandhan, Senior Nephew of Sri Ramanuja.
- **Incarnation Metadata:**
 - **Tamil Month (Maasam):** Chithirai (Chaitra)

- **Birth Star (Nakshatram):** Punarvasu
- **Tithi & Paksham:** Born c. 1027 CE; Sukla Paksha.
- **Geographic Origins:**
 - **Historic Birthplace Name:** Pachai (Nazarethpettah, near Sriperumbudur)
 - **Current District & State:** Kanchipuram District, Tamil Nadu, India.
 - **Associated Divya Desam / Temple:** Sri Ranganathaswamy Temple (Srirangam) and Singaperumal Kovil.
- **Divine Lineage & Era:**
 - **Divine Amsam:** Tridandam (The Triple Ascetic Staff of Ramanuja) / Sri Rama's Paduka (Divine Sandals) Amsam.
 - **Historical Period:** 11th–12th Century CE.
 - **Sovereign & Scholarly Contemporaries:** Sri Ramanuja (His maternal uncle and Acharya), Koorathazhwan, Embar, Kandhadhai Aandaan (His son), Chola rulers.

Section 2: Complete Life History & Miracles

2.1 Chronological Life Timeline

- **Birth as Ramanuja's Nephew:** Born as Dasarathi to Anantha Somayaji and Nachiyarammal (Ramanuja's elder sister) at Pachai → **Absolute Surrender:** Surrendering to Sri Ramanuja at a young age and becoming his shadow and administrative right hand → **The Paduka Declaration:** Ramanuja declaring that while Koorathazhwan was his mind, Mudaliyandan was his very body and divine sandals (*Yathiraja Paduka*) → **Managing Srirangam Administration:** Appointed by Ramanuja as the chief administrator (*Kevil Sree Karyam*) of the Srirangam temple complex → **Reforming Temple Rituals:** Implementing strict organizational systems for temple priests, servants, and treasuries across major shrines → **The Srivilliputhur Conquest:** Subduing opposition at Srivilliputhur and other shrines through diplomatic firm authority → **The Sanctorum Water Blessing:** Placing his feet in the water tank at Thirumanjana Kovil to purify those afflicted by ailments → **Establishing the 74 Simhasanadhipathis:** Assisting Ramanuja in organizing 74 hereditary administrative lineages to propagate Viśiṣṭādvaita → **Attainment of Paramapadam:** Serving Srirangam faithfully until his final moments, entering *Paramapadam* shortly after Ramanuja.

2.2 Deep Biographical Narrative

- **Early Years & Spiritual Awakening:** Born under the name Dasarathi in Pachai, he was Sri Ramanuja's sister's son. From childhood, Dasarathi showed complete dispassion toward worldly affairs, choosing to dedicate his life exclusively to serving his maternal uncle, Sri Ramanuja.
- **Core Seva / Kainkaryam:** Temple administration (*Srikarya Paripalanam*); enforcement of discipline and liturgy; acting as the physical representative (*Paduka*) of Sri Ramanuja.
- **Miracles & Historical Events:**
 1. *The Identity as Ramanuja's Paduka:* Sri Ramanuja famously remarked: "Koorathazhwan is my mind (*Jnana*), but Mudaliyandan is my physical body (*Sareera*). He is my divine sandals (*Paduka*)."
Because of this unique status, when Ramanuja took *Sannyasa* and had to renounce all family relationships, he refused to renounce his bond with Mudaliyandan,

- declaring that one cannot renounce one's own feet or ascetic staff.
2. *Refusal of Ego during Initiation:* When Ramanuja sent Mudaliyandan to study under Thirukoshtiyur Nambi, Nambi made Mudaliyandan wait for six months without offering instruction to test his humility. Mudaliyandan performed simple household chores, cleaning the courtyard and caring for cattle without a trace of pride. Seeing his complete freedom from ego, Thirukoshtiyur Nambi embraced him and imparted the deepest esoteric truths.
 3. *Reforming Srirangam Administration:* Ramanuja entrusted Mudaliyandan with the complete administrative charge of the Srirangam temple (*Kovil Olugu*). Mudaliyandan introduced rigorous accounting, structured priestly duties into ten traditional groups (*Kothu*), and ensured that the recitation of the *Divya Prabandham* was performed with proper decorum. His management was so flawless that he earned the title **Mudaliyandan** ("The First Leader").
- **Guru-Disciple Dynamics:** Prime nephew and disciple to Sri Ramanuja; Acharya to Kandhadhai Aandaan and founder of the Kandhadhai lineage.
 - **Attainment of Paramapadam:** Passed away at Srirangam, leaving behind a legacy of organized temple administration that continues across South Indian shrines today.
- 💡 **Sthala Puranam & Legend Highlight: The Concept of Yathiraja Paduka**
In Sri Vaishnava theology, Mudaliyandan represents the ultimate archetype of **Paduka-Prabhavatvam** (the glory of the Lord's sandals). Just as Bharata worshiped Sri Rama's sandals in the Ramayana, Sri Vaishnavas revere Mudaliyandan as the living sandals of Sri Ramanuja.

Section 3: Literary, Preservation & Philosophical Contributions

- **Complete List of Works:**
 - Systematized administrative manuals for Srirangam Kovil management (*Kovil Olugu* administrative protocols).
 - Oral transmissions of *Rahasya Arthas* preserved through the Kandhadhai lineage.
- **Quantified Output:** Administrative codification of temple liturgies.
- **Associated Divya Desams (Mangalasasanam):** Sriperumbudur, Kanchipuram, Srirangam, Srivilliputhur, Singaperumal Kovil.
- **Sampradaya Defense & Preservation:** Built the operational, administrative, and institutional backbone of the Sri Vaishnava Sampradaya. He ensured that Ramanuja's philosophical reforms were practically enforced in temple worship.
- **Predominant Bhakti Bhava & Philosophical Core:** **Acharya-Sareerathvam** (Viewing oneself as the physical instrument/body of the Acharya) and **Kainkarya-Nishta** (Unwavering dedication to administrative service).

Section 4: Representative Verses & Theological Breakdown

Verse 1: Invocation to Mudaliyandan (*Thaniyan*)

Text Layer	Content
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Original Script (Sanskrit)	பாதுகே யதிராஜஸ்ய கதயந்தி யதாக்யயா । தஸ்ய தாஸரதேஃ பாதொ ஸிரஸா தாரயாம்யஹம் ॥
Roman Transliteration	<i>Paduke Yathirajasya kathayanti yadakhya</i> <i>Tasya Dasaratheh padau shirasa dharmyam</i>
Literal Word-by-Word Meaning	Paduke: The divine sandals; Yathirajasya: of Yathiraja (Sri Ramanuja); Kathayanti: who is described; Yad akhya: by whose very name; Tasya: of that; Dasaratheh: Dasarathi (Mudaliyandan); Padau: the lotus feet; Shirasa: upon my head; Dharmyam: I bear with deep reverence!

Exhaustive Theological & Philosophical Commentary:

1. **Esoteric Meaning (Swaroopa Jnanam):** This invocation verse offers salutations to Sri Mudaliyandan (Dasarathi), identifying him directly as the divine sandals (*Paduka*) of Sri Ramanuja (*Yathiraja*). The devotee places Mudaliyandan's lotus feet upon their head, seeking his grace to approach Ramanuja.
2. **Viśiṣṭādvaita Alignment:** Illustrates **Charama Parva Adhikara** (The ultimate stage of surrender: taking refuge in the servant of the Guru). In Sri Vaishnavism, one approaches Sriman Narayana through Sri Lakshmi, Sri Lakshmi through Ramanuja, and Ramanuja through his divine sandals—Mudaliyandan.
3. **Commentarial Insights:** Sri Manavala Mamunigal in *Upadesa Rathnamalai* highlights that Mudaliyandan demonstrated how administrative authority (*Srikaryam*) can be executed with complete personal humility, serving as a model for all temple administrators.

Section 5: Visuals & Archival Resources

5.1 Iconography & Shrine Visual Description

- **Physical Posture (Asana):** Standing in a posture of alert readiness or seated in *Anjali Mudra* beside Sri Ramanuja.
- **Hand Gestures (Mudras):** Hands joined in *Anjali Mudra* or holding a palm-leaf record scroll (*Olai*) detailing temple administration.
- **Garments & Embellishments:** Dressed in traditional white householder vestments, marked with twelve *Urdhva Pundra* (tilak) marks, wearing sacred thread and *Tulasi* garlands.

- **Avathara Sthalam Idol Description:** At Nazarethpettah (Pachai) and Srirangam, Mudaliyandan's idol stands beside Ramanuja, capturing his role as the eternal shadow and protector of his master.

5.2 Academic Audio/Video Lecture Queries

- "Mudaliyandan Life History and Srirangam Administration Velukkudi Krishnan"
- "Yathiraja Paduka Mudaliyandan Vaibhavam Karunakarachariar"
- "Mudaliyandan and 74 Simhasanadhipathis Ananthapadmanabhachariar"

5.3 Digital Text & Archival Links

- **Dravida Veda Repository:** <http://www.dravidaveda.org>
- **Project Madurai Texts:** <https://www.projectmadurai.org>
- **Koyil Archival Library:** <https://koyil.org>

4. EMBAR

(Govinda Bhattar, Embar, Ramanuja-Saho-Dhara, Kalahasti Reclaimed Saint)

Section 1: Identification & Incarnation Details

- **Full Name & Titles:** Embar, Govinda Bhattar, Govinda Jeeyar, Ramanuja-Padanudhyatha, The Reclaimed Saint of Kalahasti, Successor to Ramanuja at Srirangam.
- **Incarnation Metadata:**
 - **Tamil Month (Maasam):** Thai (Makaram)
 - **Birth Star (Nakshatram):** Punarvasu
 - **Tithi & Paksham:** Born c. 1026 CE; Sukla Paksha.
- **Geographic Origins:**
 - **Historic Birthplace Name:** Mazhalaimangalam (Maduramangalam, near Sriperumbudur)
 - **Current District & State:** Kanchipuram District, Tamil Nadu, India.
 - **Associated Divya Desam / Temple:** Sri Ranganathaswamy Temple (Srirangam) and Kalahasti Temple.
- **Divine Lineage & Era:**
 - **Divine Amsam:** Ananta / Adishesha aspect (Maternal cousin brother of Sri Ramanuja).
 - **Historical Period:** 11th–12th Century CE.
 - **Sovereign & Scholarly Contemporaries:** Sri Ramanuja (His cousin and Acharya), Thirumalai Nambi (His maternal uncle who reclaimed him), Parasara Bhattar (His primary disciple), Koorathazhwan.

Section 2: Complete Life History & Miracles

2.1 Chronological Life Timeline

- **Birth & Early Education:** Born as Govinda Bhattar to Kamalaksha Bhattar and Sridevi Ammal (Ramanuja's mother's sister) at Maduramangalam → **Rescuing Ramanuja at Vindhyas:** Alerting Ramanuja to Yadava Prakasa's murder plot during the Varanasi pilgrimage → **Conversion to Saivism at Kalahasti:** Finding a divine lingam in his hand while bathing at the Ganges, moving to Kalahasti, becoming a staunch Saivite, and taking the name *Ullangai Startha Nayanar* → **Reclamation by Thirumalai Nambi:** Thirumalai Nambi visiting Kalahasti, chanting Nammalwar's Pasurams outside his path, and

re-awakening his Vaishnava heritage → **Renunciation & Sannyasa:** Discarding Saivite emblems, taking Vaishnava initiation, becoming an ascetic (*Embar*), and joining Ramanuja at Srirangam → **The Snake-in-Frog's-Mouth Miracle:** Putting his hand into a snake's mouth to remove a painful thorn choking a frog, demonstrating boundless compassion for all living beings → **Tending to Ramanuja's Bed:** Checking Ramanuja's bed for thorns by lying on it himself before his master slept → **Instructing Parasara Bhattar:** Chosen by Ramanuja to be the spiritual preceptor to Koorathazhwan's brilliant young son, Parasara Bhattar → **Head of Srirangam Math:** Succeeding Ramanuja as head of the Srirangam Math → **Attainment of Paramapadam:** Passing away after transferring spiritual leadership to Parasara Bhattar.

2.2 Deep Biographical Narrative

- **Early Years & Spiritual Awakening:** Born in Maduramangalam as Ramanuja's maternal cousin, Govinda Bhattar was deeply attached to Ramanuja from childhood. During the pilgrimage to Varanasi with Yadava Prakasa, Govinda overheard the conspiracy to kill Ramanuja in the Vindhya forest and secretly warned him to flee.
- **Core Seva / Kainkaryam:** Personal service (*Antharanga Kainkaryam*) to Sri Ramanuja; guardianship and education of Parasara Bhattar; leading the Srirangam Math.
- **Miracles & Historical Events:**
 1. *The Reclamation at Kalahasti:* Continuing his pilgrimage to Varanasi, Govinda found a small lingam in his palm while bathing in the Ganges. Believing it to be a divine sign, he became a devoted Saivite ascetic at Kalahasti, known as *Ullangai Startha Nayanar*. Distressed that his brilliant cousin was lost to Saivism, Ramanuja requested their uncle Thirumalai Nambi to reclaim him. Thirumalai Nambi traveled to Kalahasti, stood near the garden where Govinda gathered flowers, and sang Nammalwar's *Tiruvaymoli* verse: "*Tanum Sivanum Brahmavum Tanaiyilla Vaanum...*" Hearing the supreme truth of Narayana expressed in sweet Tamil, Govinda threw away his flower basket, tore off his Saivite beads, fell at Thirumalai Nambi's feet, and returned to Sri Vaishnavism.
 2. *The Compassion for the Frog:* One day, while walking with disciples, Embar saw a frog writhing in agony inside a bush. A venomous snake had swallowed the frog, but a sharp thorn was jammed in the snake's jaw, causing excruciating pain to both creatures. Without hesitating, Embar fearlessly thrust his hand into the snake's open mouth, removed the thorn, and freed the frog. When disciples warned him of the fatal poison, Embar replied: "*How could I worry about my physical body when two living beings created by Narayana were suffering before my eyes?*"
 3. *Testing the Acharya's Bed:* Every night, Embar inspected Ramanuja's bed before his master retired. He would lie down on the bed himself and roll across it. When criticized by other disciples for disrespecting the Acharya's bed, Embar explained: "*If there are hidden thorns or insects, let them bite my body first, so my Acharya may sleep peacefully.*" Moved by his selflessness, Ramanuja embraced him, calling him **Embar** ("My Master").
- **Guru-Disciple Dynamics:** Cousin and disciple to Sri Ramanuja; Reclaimed disciple of Thirumalai Nambi; Acharya to Parasara Bhattar.
- **Attainment of Paramapadam:** Passed away peacefully at Srirangam after handing over

the reign of the Sri Vaishnava Sampradaya to Parasara Bhattar.

💡 Sthala Puranam & Legend Highlight: Maduramangalam Shrine & Embar's Name

Maduramangalam is the sacred birth site of Embar, housing a dedicated temple and holy tank. The name **Embar** was given to him by Sri Ramanuja as an abbreviation of *Em-Perumanar* ("My Master"), honoring his supreme personal devotion.

Section 3: Literary, Preservation & Philosophical Contributions

- **Complete List of Works:**
 - *Embar Thaniyan* on Sri Ramanuja (*Ramanuja Daya Patram...*).
 - Oral commentaries on *Tiruvaymoli* transmitted to Parasara Bhattar.
- **Quantified Output:** Oral transmission of *Dravida Veda* commentaries and 1 foundational *Thaniyan*.
- **Associated Divya Desams (Mangalasasanam):** Maduramangalam, Kanchipuram, Kalahasti, Srirangam, Tirupati.
- **Sampradaya Defense & Preservation:** Preserved the intellectual continuity of the Sampradaya by nurturing Parasara Bhattar, ensuring that Yamunacharya's second vow (naming a scholar after Parasara) bore fruit.
- **Predominant Bhakti Bhava & Philosophical Core:** **Daya / Karunya** (Universal compassion toward all living beings) and **Antharanga Kainkaryam** (Intimate personal service to the Guru).

Section 4: Representative Verses & Theological Breakdown

Verse 1: Invocation to Sri Ramanuja (*Thaniyan* composed by Embar)

Text Layer	Content
Original Script (<i>Sanskrit</i>)	ஸ்ரீமத்யமுனமுனிந்தரபதாம்புஜப்ருங் காய ஸ்ரீமதே । ராமானுஜாய முனயே குரவே நமோஸ்து நஃ ॥
Roman Transliteration	<i>Srimad Yamunamunindra padambuja bhringaya srimate</i> <i>Ramanujaya munaye kurave namo 'stu nah</i>
Literal Word-by-Word Meaning	Srimad: Possessing divine luster/grace; Yamuna munindra: of Yamunacharya, the prince among sages; Pada ambuja: lotus feet; Bhringaya: who acts like a humble honeybee; Srimate: who is accompanied

	by spiritual wealth; Ramanujaya munaye: to the sage Ramanuja; Kurave: to my supreme preceptor; Namo 'stu nah: let our humble salutations be offered!
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Exhaustive Theological & Philosophical Commentary:

1. **Esoteric Meaning (Swaroopam Jnanam):** Embar composes this invocation in honor of his Acharya, Sri Ramanuja. He compares Ramanuja to a golden honeybee (*Bhringa*) perpetually drinking the divine nectar flowing from the lotus feet of Sri Yamunacharya (*Yamunamunindra*).
2. **Viśiṣṭādvaita Alignment:** Demonstrates the principle of **Guru-Parampara-Anusandhanam** (Contemplating the unbroken chain of preceptors). Embar highlights that Ramanuja's authority derives directly from his deep absorption in the legacy of Yamunacharya.
3. **Commentarial Insights:** Nampillai highlights that Embar chose the metaphor of a honeybee (*Bhringa*) because a bee collects only sweet nectar without harming the flower. Similarly, Ramanuja extracted the pure essence of Vedic truth (*Vedārtha Sangraha*) without distorting scriptural texts.

Section 5: Visuals & Archival Resources

5.1 Iconography & Shrine Visual Description

- **Physical Posture (Asana):** Seated in *Ardha Padmasana* or standing in *Anjali Mudra* facing Sri Ramanuja.
- **Hand Gestures (Mudras):** Hands joined in *Anjali Mudra* or held in *Jnana Mudra*.
- **Garments & Embellishments:** Dressed in ascetic robes (*Kasaya Vasthram*), marked with twelve *Urdhva Pundra* (tilak) marks, wearing sacred thread and *Tulasi* seed garlands.
- **Avathara Sthalam Idol Description:** At Maduramangalam and Srirangam, Embar's idol captures his serene, compassionate expression, capturing his identity as the gentle saint who rescued both frogs and disciples.

5.2 Academic Audio/Video Lecture Queries

- "Embar Life History and Kalahasti Reclamation Velukkudi Krishnan"
- "Embar Compassion and Frog Miracle Karunakarachariar"
- "Maduramangalam Embar Vaibhavam Ananthapadmanabhachariar"

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